How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them

A Plain-Language Guide for Any Nation, Any Government, Any Citizen

This document explains a simple method for spotting dangerous stories about other countries, replacing them with honest ones, and channelling the energy nations spend on rivalry into things other than war. Every section stands on its own, so nothing earlier needs to be remembered to understand what follows. It is written to be useful to any government, in any country, without asking anyone to take a side.

1. The Big Idea, in Three Sentences

Wars almost never start with a weapon. They start with a story that makes the weapon feel necessary, or even right. Catch the dangerous story early, and offer a better one that still serves everyone's real interests, and conflict can often be stopped before it starts.

2. The Four Warning Signs of a Dangerous Story

Watch for these in any story about another nation, including stories your own country tells about itself:

- It says the outcome is inevitable, which makes people feel there is no point trying to stop it.
- It makes the other side sound evil by nature, not just wrong about one thing, which makes negotiation feel pointless.
- It only offers two choices, when a middle path almost always exists.
- It leans on an old grievance to justify a new action, making compromise feel like betrayal.

These four signs appear on every side of every conflict. A method that only looks for them in rivals, never in oneself, is not honesty. It is propaganda with better footnotes.

3. Why Fear Traps Nations Even When Everyone Would Prefer Peace

Here is a pattern well known to economists and diplomats, sometimes called the security dilemma, and closely related to an idea from mathematics called the Nash equilibrium: a stable outcome where no single side can improve its own position by changing course alone, even if a different, better outcome exists for everyone together. Two nations can both genuinely prefer peace and still end up locked in an arms race, because neither can safely be the first to stand down while the other might not. The table below shows the trap in its simplest form.

	If the other nation also chooses trust	If the other nation chooses fear and arms up
If we choose trust and de-escalate	Best outcome for everyone: lower costs, lower risk, more resources for people instead of weapons.	Worst outcome for us: we look exposed, which is exactly why leaders fear choosing this first.
If we choose fear and arm up	Worse for everyone than mutual trust, but feels 'safer' than being the exposed one.	The common trap: both sides poorer and less safe than mutual trust would have made them, yet neither can afford to be first to stand down.

The way out is not persuading either side that peace is a nicer idea. Both sides usually already believe that. The way out is changing the payoffs, through verified, reciprocal steps, so that trust becomes the individually safer choice too, not just the collectively better one. This is why the practical proposals later in this document focus on verification and mutual, checkable steps rather than appeals to goodwill alone.

4. The Six-Step Method

A plain question to ask about any story you hear about another country, before deciding whether to believe or repeat it.

Step	Plain Question	Why It Matters
1	Who is telling me this, and what do they gain if I believe it?	Every storyteller has a reason. Knowing it doesn't make them wrong, but tells you how carefully to check.
2	Which part is a fact, and which part is just one way of describing that fact?	Facts and framing get blended together on purpose. Separating them is the whole skill.
3	What would make the storyteller want to tell a truer story instead?	People repeat stories that reward them. Change the reward, and the story can change.
4	Can I offer a truer story that still lets everyone save face?	A better story spreads faster if no one has to admit total defeat to adopt it.
5	Who does my audience already trust, and can that messenger help share it?	A true fact from a stranger travels slower than the same fact from someone already trusted.
6	What actually changed in the real world, not just in the headlines?	Policy, trade, and votes are the only real scoreboard. Everything else is noise.

5. A Real Precedent: When Two Nations Rewrote Their Shared History Together

This is not a hypothetical. In 2003, five hundred French and German secondary school students gathered in Berlin for the fortieth anniversary of the Franco-German friendship treaty, and proposed something simple: a single history textbook, with identical content, used in both countries. Their governments took up the idea. Historians from both nations worked together, and in 2006 the textbook, Histoire and Geschichte, was published jointly, becoming the world's first shared secondary-school history book produced by two countries with a long history of war between them. It built on an even older effort: a Franco-German textbook commission had been quietly doing similar work since 1951, and a parallel German-Polish textbook commission has operated since 1972.

The sequence matters as much as the result: it began with young people and academics, not with politicians, and only became government policy once the groundwork existed. Commentators in East Asia have since pointed to this model directly as a possible template for their own region's more difficult shared histories. This is the real-world version of the roundtable process proposed later in this document: start with historians and academics reviewing a shared past honestly together, let politicians formalize what already has scholarly consensus, then widen the table to more nations.

6. Necessity as the Engine of Invention: What Vaccine Development Teaches the World

New vaccines normally take ten to fifteen years to move from an idea to approval. Before 2020, the fastest a vaccine had ever been developed was the mumps vaccine in 1967, at four years, and that was considered remarkably fast at the time. When COVID-19 became a global emergency, the first vaccines were developed, tested, and authorized in eleven months.

Vaccine Development Effort	Time From Start to Approval	Conditions
Typical new vaccine, historical average	10 to 15 years	Normal funding and regulatory pace, no global emergency driving it.
Mumps vaccine (1967), the fastest ever developed before 2020	4 years	Considered remarkably fast at the time.
COVID-19 mRNA vaccines (2020)	11 months from genetic sequence to emergency authorization	Global emergency funding, parallel rather than sequential trial phases, and decades of prior mRNA research already in place. An aside: (*Luck is preparation meeting opportunity.)*

This was not a shortcut on safety. What changed was the removal of sequential waiting: trial phases that normally run one after another ran in parallel, funding that normally arrives in stages arrived up front, and decades of prior, unrelated research on the underlying mRNA technology was already sitting on the shelf, ready to be applied the moment it was needed. The lesson for the rest of the world is general, not specific to any one crisis: when a society treats a problem as urgent enough to remove the normal waiting built into how progress happens, timelines that seem fixed can compress by a factor of ten or more. Climate change is, on every measure, a comparably urgent problem. The open question this document poses is whether humanity can apply anything close to that same intensity of focus to the green transition without first waiting for a crisis severe enough to force it.

7. AI Is Already Compressing the Green Timeline

There is early, real evidence that focused technological effort, this time from artificial intelligence rather than wartime urgency, is already doing exactly that in specific domains. The table below shows how AI is changing the cost and speed of both resource extraction and the green transition at the same time, often through the same tools.

Domain	Traditional Pace/Cost	AI-Accelerated Effect	Why It Matters for Both Sides at Once
Mineral exploration	Drill success rates as low as 0.5%; discovery rates down about 75% over the last decade.	AI-guided targeting could cut discovery costs by up to 80%, an estimated \$290–390 billion in savings by 2035.	Cheaper, more precise extraction with a smaller physical footprint, since fewer exploratory sites need to be disturbed.
Battery and green-material design	New stable materials historically took months to years to identify and confirm.	DeepMind's GNoME model identified 2.2 million candidate crystal structures, with roughly 380,000 assessed as stable, in a single project.	Shrinks the research phase of the green transition from a matter of decades to a matter of years.
Electricity grid management	Solar and wind power are intermittent and historically hard to store and route efficiently.	AI grid-optimization tools are already helping route and store solar power more efficiently, reducing reliance on fossil-fuel backup.	Makes renewable power more reliable without needing to overbuild fossil-fuel backup capacity.

The throughline across all three rows is the same: AI does not just make old processes marginally faster. It changes what is economically possible at all, in extraction and in the clean-energy buildout simultaneously, often using the very same underlying models.

8. What Nobody Wants, Anywhere: An Expanded Common Ground

We cannot know everything every nation wants. But we know, with far more confidence, what almost nobody wants, in any country: **hunger, poverty, and war**. **Climate change** is now adding new items to that short, nearly universal list, ones that make the case for cooperation, even without appealing to shared values, only shared exposure.

Shared Threat	What It Looks Like Now	Who It Spares
Hunger	Present in every country in some form, worsened by conflict and disrupted trade.	No one, anywhere
Poverty	Shaped differently by geography, but universally understood as a threat to dignity and stability.	No one, anywhere
War	Destroys the shared prosperity every side claims to be protecting.	No one, anywhere
Climate-driven disease spread	Warming has expanded the range of disease-carrying ticks and mosquitoes; in the United States alone, the lone star tick's spread is now linked to a rising, real allergy to red meat, alpha-gal syndrome, once confined to the southeast and now confirmed as far north as Maine.	Every warming region, regardless of politics
Young people losing hope	Rising numbers of young people worldwide report climate anxiety and political disillusionment severe enough to affect whether they plan for a future at all.	Every nation's next generation

None of these threats respect borders, ideology, or which narrative a country prefers to tell about itself. That is precisely what makes them a stronger foundation for cooperation than almost anything else on the table.

9. Replacing War With Something Else: The Olympic Model

If competition between nations is a constant, the practical question is what channel that competition runs through. The modern Olympic Games are a long-running, real example of a structure that channels national rivalry into a form that is not war: nations compete openly and by agreed rules, while also collaborating on the shared infrastructure, refereeing, and norms that make the competition possible at all. It is one documented model, among others, of competition and collaboration operating at the same time rather than as opposites.

10. A Specific Ask

Not general encouragement to do better, but one concrete, fundable proposal: that UNESCO, together with willing national academies of history, convene a standing International Joint History and Narrative Review Panel, modeled explicitly on the Franco-German and German-Polish textbook commissions described in Section 5. It should begin with two willing nations within eighteen months, with participants nominated by national academies rather than appointed directly by governments, mirroring the sequence that made the Franco-German model credible: academics first, formal government adoption only once scholarly consensus already exists.

11. Where to Check Everything in This Document Yourself

- Georg Eckert Institute (Leibniz Institute for Educational Media), history of the Franco-German Textbook Commission since 1951
- Wikipedia, "Histoire/Geschichte," the 2006 joint Franco-German history textbook
- Georg Eckert Institute, history of the Joint German-Polish Textbook Commission since 1972
- McKinsey & Company, on typical versus COVID-19 vaccine development timelines
- Johns Hopkins Coronavirus Resource Center, on typical 5-to-10-year vaccine development timelines
- BioSpace, on the 1967 mumps vaccine as the previous fastest-ever vaccine development
- Cleantech Group, on AI-driven mineral exploration cost savings
- Science (AAAS), on DeepMind's GNoME materials-discovery model
- Tulsa Health Department, on alpha-gal syndrome and the climate-driven range expansion of the lone star tick
- Alpha-gal Information (clinical resource), on confirmed alpha-gal cases as far north as Maine

12. One-Sentence Summary

Check who benefits from a story, separate fact from framing, change the incentives rather than just stating the truth louder, and point the energy of nations toward opportunities. Remove, mitigate threats. No single nation can out-compete its way past, alone.